analyst Nouriel Roubini, in a piece called 'Another BRIC in the wall?', wondered whether Russia was not in fact 'more sick than BRIC' (Roubini 2011).

Clearly, the health of the Russian economy has gone through extreme variations. In Russia, the decade after the collapse of the Soviet Union closed with a grim balance: an abysmal contraction of the economy (about 50% of GDP was wiped out only between 1991 and 1994) and a situation in which all main economic and social indicators nosedived (for an exceptionally clear and synthetic overview, see Pirani 2010, chapter 7; see also Cook 2012). Much of that story is not particular to Russia, and indeed horrific (often higher) levels of poverty and inequality have plagued and continue to plague the development prospects of China and, more directly, Brazil, India and South Africa. What is key in the case of Russia is that poverty and inequality – for the most part, the consequence of 20 years of harsh neoliberal reforms – exacerbate an essential element of negative contrast to the other BICS beyond economic metrics: population decline – and remember that demographics was one of the main methodological pillars in the original definition of a BRICS according to Wilson and Purushothanam (2003, Appendix III). In demographic terms, Russia clearly stands out. According to Simon Pirani:

> The death rate [in Russia], having hit an all-time high in the early 1990s, fell temporarily in the late 1990s, but in the 2000s increased. Mortality among men of working age is three to five times higher, and among women twice as high, as in other countries at similar levels of economic development. Those living on the verge of poverty, and suffering high levels of alcoholism, poor nutrition, lack of healthcare, and psychological stress, are most prone to dying young … High death rates have combined with a constantly falling birth rate to produce a sharp decline in Russia's population, and demographers expect this to continue in the coming decades (2010:134).

So back in 2000, as O'Neill was working out his first BRIC formulation, Russia's death rate soared over its birth rate, with a further decline in the fertility rate between perestroika and 1999 of close to 50%. Taken together, these figures mean that the number of Russian women of childbearing age has fallen sharply, which in turn works to dampen Russia's future demographic prospects even more. Although fertility rates have recovered since Putin first took office, the overall size of the Russian population is down by three million people since 1991, and this decline, even when it has substantially decelerated, will remain